GEMINI NOTEBOOK

The Guidebook

For jobs, admissions or any study —
how to use it the right way.

Study from your own books and notes,
using only your mobile.

SETUP · SOURCES · 10 TESTED PROMPTS · TROUBLESHOOTING · CHECKLIST

14 pages · By Saurabh Saha · 2026 Edition

START HERE

Why Gemini Notebook changes how you study

Normal AI chat apps answer from their own general training. They sound confident, but you cannot see where an answer came from — and for exam study, one wrong date or formula can cost you marks.

Gemini Notebook (Google's NotebookLM) works the opposite way. You first give it **your** sources — your textbook, your notes, your PDFs. After that, it answers **only from those sources**, and puts a small number beside every answer. Tap the number and it shows you the exact line it used. For a student, that number is everything: it means you can trust, verify and revise from the same material your examiner uses.



What this guidebook gives you

- **Setup** — get running on your phone in under five minutes (page 3).
- **Sources** — what to add, how to add it, and how to organise it (pages 5–6).
- **10 tested prompts** — copy-ready questions that produce summaries, MCQs, quizzes and revision sheets (pages 10–11).
- **Troubleshooting** — the common problems and their fixes (page 13).
- **One-page checklist** — tear-off style page for daily study (page 14).

You need nothing except a mobile phone and a Google account. Everything in this book is shown for mobile first.

CHAPTER 1

Setup: five minutes, once

Gemini Notebook is the mobile name for Google NotebookLM — same product, same notebooks, on phone and computer both.

On Android or iPhone

1. Open the **Play Store** (Android) or **App Store** (iPhone) and search **“NotebookLM”** — install the official Google app. No phone? Open **notebooklm.google.com** in your mobile browser; everything in this book works there too.
2. Open the app and sign in with your **Google account**. Use the same account on every device so your notebooks stay in sync.
3. Tap **“+ New”** (or “Create new”) to make your first notebook. You will land on the **Add sources** screen — that is page 5 of this book.
4. Allow the app to access your files when it asks. Without file permission it cannot attach your PDFs and notes.

Good settings to fix now

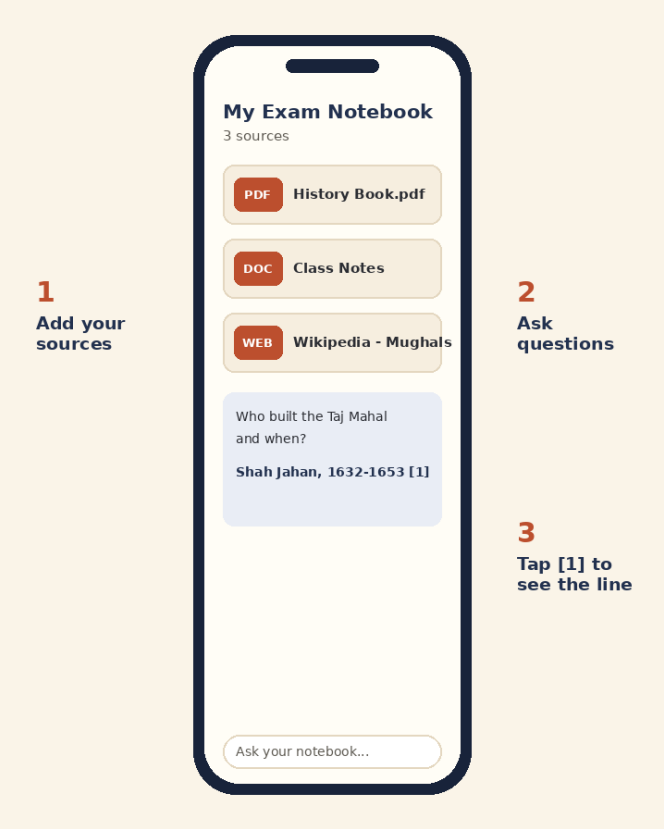
- **One account, always.** Notebooks do not transfer between Google accounts.
- **Turn on app notifications off** if you study in silence — NotebookLM does not need them.
- **Language:** answers come in the language of your question. Ask in English, get English; ask in your language, get that. You can mix both in one notebook.
- **Free plan is enough** to start: up to 100 notebooks and 50 sources per notebook. Paid plans raise limits; this book assumes the free plan.

Safety note: only upload books and notes you have the right to use, and never upload anyone’s private documents. Your sources are private to your account — nobody else can see them.

CHAPTER 2

Your first notebook, and the three screens

Think of a notebook as one subject's folder. One notebook for History, one for Reasoning, one for English — never one giant notebook for everything. Separate notebooks give sharper answers, because the AI searches only inside that subject.



The three screens you will live in

- **Sources (left panel)** — everything you added. Tick or untick a source to include or exclude it from answers.
- **Chat (centre)** — where you ask questions and read answers with citation numbers.
- **Studio (right panel)** — where you create study material: audio summaries, flashcards, quizzes, mind maps and reports (pages 8–9).

Name notebooks clearly — "Bank GK – History" beats "New notebook 3" when you have ten of them before an exam.

CHAPTER 3

Adding sources: what works

Sources are the heart of the system. Gemini Notebook can only answer from what you give it — so the quality of your sources decides the quality of every answer.



How to add a source (mobile)

1. Open your notebook and tap **“+ Add source”** in the Sources panel.
2. Choose the type: **PDF / file** from your phone, a **website link**, a **YouTube link**, or **copied text** pasted directly.
3. Wait for the tick mark. A source is ready only when processing finishes and it appears in the list with a checkbox.
4. Tap the source once to see its **summary and key topics** — a quick check that the file loaded correctly.
5. Repeat. A strong exam notebook usually has 5–15 good sources, not 50 random ones.

On the free plan each notebook holds up to **50 sources**, and each source can be up to **500,000 words** — a full textbook fits easily.

CHAPTER 3 · CONTINUED

Source tips that make answers better

Most “AI gave a bad answer” problems are actually source problems. Fix the sources and the answers fix themselves.

Do this

- **Prefer text PDFs over scanned photos.** If your PDF is a scan, the text may be unreadable. Run it through any free “OCR PDF” tool first, or add clear photos page by page.
- **Add the official material first** — syllabus, textbook, official notes — then coaching notes. Order does not matter, but trust does: verify answers against official sources.
- **One chapter per file beats one giant file** when you can split it. Citations point to the exact place, and small files process faster.
- **Rename every source** (tap ■ → Rename): “History Ch 4 – Mughal Empire” helps you pick sources in seconds.
- **Untick, don’t delete,** when revising one chapter — unticked sources are ignored for that chat only.
- **Add last year’s question papers** as sources. Half of smart preparation is knowing what examiners actually ask (prompt 9, page 11).

Avoid this

- Do not add the same file twice — duplicates confuse citations.
- Do not add other people’s private documents or paid material you do not own.
- Do not trust a source that itself is wrong. NotebookLM repeats your sources faithfully — including their mistakes.

CHAPTER 4

Asking questions and using citations

The Chat screen is where studying actually happens. Type a question in plain words — the way you would ask a teacher — and press send.

How to read an answer

- **Citation numbers** like [1] [2] sit beside sentences. Tap one: the source opens at the exact line used. Read that line — this 10-second habit is what makes your preparation reliable.
- **Long answer? Ask for the format you want:** “in 5 bullet points”, “as a table”, “in simple words”. Format instructions work very well.
- **Follow up.** “Give one example.” “Now the opposite case.” Follow-ups stay inside the same topic and sources.
- **Save good answers as notes:** use “Save to note” on any answer. Saved notes collect in the Studio panel and can themselves become a source for the whole notebook — your revision material builds itself.
- **Start a new chat** when you change topic inside the same notebook, so old questions do not colour new answers.

Three question styles that always work

1. **Fetch:** “List all causes of the 1857 revolt mentioned in my sources.”
2. **Explain:** “Explain the water cycle from Chapter 3 as if I am 15 years old.”
3. **Test:** “Ask me one question at a time from this chapter and check my answers.” (Full prompt on page 10.)

If it says “I could not find that in your sources”, believe it — the topic is missing or worded differently in your material. Add the right source instead of arguing.

CHAPTER 5

The Studio: study material in one tap

Open the **Studio** panel in any notebook and you can generate study material from your sources automatically. These five tools cover most of exam preparation:

Tool	What it makes	Best used for
Study Guide	Short-answer questions with an answer key, plus a glossary of key terms.	Full-chapter revision
Briefing Doc	A clean summary document of the main themes and quotes.	First reading of a new chapter
FAQ	Likely questions and answers from your sources.	Interview and viva prep
Timeline	Events in date order with the people involved.	History and current affairs
Mind Map	A diagram of how the main ideas connect.	Seeing the whole chapter at once

How to generate any of them

1. Tick only the sources you want included (one chapter = cleaner output).
2. Open **Studio** → **choose the tool**. Generation takes under a minute.
3. Read the output, then **save it as a note**. Saved notes become sources too — ask questions on your own study guide later.

Generated material is only as good as its sources. If a study guide misses a topic, that topic is missing (or too thin) in your sources — add material, then regenerate.

CHAPTER 5 · CONTINUED

Flashcards, quizzes and audio overviews

Flashcards and Quizzes

In the Studio panel, choose **Flashcards** or **Quiz**, set the number of questions and difficulty if asked, and generate. Flashcards flip on tap — ideal for dates, formulas, vocabulary and one-line facts. Quizzes give multiple-choice questions with explanations after each answer, which is the closest thing to a real exam hall inside your phone.

A smart routine: after finishing a chapter, generate a 10-question quiz *before* you look at the study guide. Your score tells you exactly what to revise.

Audio Overview — your chapter as a podcast

Tap **Audio Overview** → **Generate** and two AI hosts discuss your sources like a podcast, usually 6–15 minutes. Download it and listen while travelling, walking or doing chores — dead time becomes revision time.

- **Customise it:** before generating, tap the customise option and type what to focus on — “focus only on dates and causes, skip introductions”.
- **Interactive mode** (where available) lets you join the conversation and ask the hosts a question mid-episode.
- **One per chapter is enough.** Re-listening to the same overview a day later, at 1.25× speed, is excellent spaced repetition.

Video overviews and slide-style summaries are also rolling out in the Studio panel — if you see them in your app, the same source-ticking rules apply.

CHAPTER 6

10 tested prompts — part 1

Copy these exactly, replacing the parts in [brackets]. Each one is tested against textbook-style sources.

1. Chapter Summary

“Summarise this chapter in 10 bullet points. Keep every date, name and number exactly as written in the source.”

Use first, on any new chapter. Your 10-minute entry point.

2. MCQ Maker

“Make 15 multiple-choice questions from this chapter, 4 options each, from easy to hard. Put the answer key at the very end, separately.”

Objective exams (SSC, banking, PSC). Cover the paper before scrolling to the key.

3. Explain Simply

“Explain [topic] as if I am 15 years old. Use one everyday example, then give the proper exam definition in the last line.”

For any topic you keep re-reading without understanding.

4. Rapid-Fire Test

“Ask me one question at a time from this chapter. Wait for my answer. Tell me if it is right or wrong with the correct line from the source, then ask the next question. Continue until I say stop.”

The single best revision prompt in this book. Use daily.

5. Fact Extractor

“List every date, year, person and number mentioned in this chapter, in a table with three columns: Fact, Value, One-line context.”

History, GK and science chapters full of forgettable facts.

CHAPTER 6 · CONTINUED

10 tested prompts — part 2

6. Compare Two Topics

“Compare [A] and [B] in a table: definition, 3 features, one example each, and one line on how an examiner usually asks about them.”

Confusing pairs — mitosis/meiosis, GDP/GNP, there/their.

7. Answer Outline (10 marks)

“Give me a structured outline for a 10-mark answer on [topic]: introduction in 2 lines, 5 body points each backed by a line from the sources, and a 2-line conclusion.”

Long-answer papers. Practise writing from the outline, not from memory of the answer.

8. Hard Quiz

“Quiz me with 10 difficult questions from the second half of this chapter only. No definitions, only application and reasoning. Explain each answer after I respond.”

In the last two weeks before the exam, when easy questions stop helping.

9. Examiner’s Eye

“From these sources and the previous-year questions I added, write 5 long-answer questions an examiner is most likely to set, and give model answer points for each.”

Needs last year’s paper added as a source (page 6). Pure gold for prediction.

10. One-Page Revision Sheet

“Turn this chapter into a one-page revision sheet: 8 key terms with meanings, 5 must-remember facts, and 3 common mistakes students make in this chapter.”

Generate one per chapter; read all sheets on the morning of the exam.

Make prompts yours: add your exam name, marks, and language — “Make 15 MCQs, SSC level, in simple English” — and save the best versions as notes inside the notebook.

CHAPTER 7

A daily workflow that actually sticks

Tools do not pass exams; routines do. This 90-minute daily pattern fits around a job or college, and every step uses something from this book.

When	25–40 minutes	What to do
Morning	New chapter	Add the chapter as a source. Read the Briefing Doc, then run Prompt 1 (Summary). Listen to yesterday's Audio Overview while getting ready.
Afternoon	Deep study	Study Guide + your textbook together. Run Prompt 4 (Rapid-Fire) for 15 minutes. Save every wrong answer as a note.
Evening	Test & close	One Quiz (10 questions). Run Prompt 5 or 10 for today's chapter. Tick today's line on the checklist (page 14).

The 7-day rhythm

- **Days 1–5:** one new chapter a day, following the table above.
- **Day 6:** no new chapter. Prompt 8 (Hard Quiz) on the week's weakest chapter + re-listen to all audio overviews.
- **Day 7:** rest, or one light Prompt 9 session planning next week's chapters.
- **Always:** wrong answers become notes; notes become sources; sources make the next quiz smarter. That loop is the whole system.

CHAPTER 8

Troubleshooting: problems and fixes

Problem	Fix
“Could not find that in your sources”	The topic is not in your material, or is worded very differently. Add the right chapter/PDF, or re-ask using the exact heading words from your book.
Answer looks wrong	Tap the citation number and read the source line yourself. If the source itself is wrong, replace it — the notebook repeats your sources faithfully.
PDF will not upload / keeps failing	Check the file opens on your phone first. Scanned PDFs should be OCR-processed; very large files can be split chapter-wise. Try the website link version if the app struggles.
YouTube link rejected	Only public videos work, and very recent uploads may not have transcripts yet. Wait a day, or add the video’s notes/slides as a PDF instead.
Answers feel too general	Untick unrelated sources so only this chapter is active, start a fresh chat, and ask for a format: “in a table”, “with dates”, “from Chapter 4 only”.
Audio Overview button missing / failed	It needs at least one processed source and a stable connection. Regenerate after a minute; long notebooks generate slower. Download episodes on Wi-Fi.
Notebook or sources disappeared	You are almost certainly signed into a different Google account. Sign out and back in with the account you created the notebook on.
Hit a limit message	Free-plan daily limits reset the next day. Split work across days, keep notebooks tidy, and delete duplicate sources to stay well under limits.

Still stuck? Notebooks and sources are tied to your Google account, so most “bugs” are account, file-quality or limit issues — check those three first, in that order.

KEEP THIS PAGE

The one-page checklist

Print this page or keep it as your phone wallpaper’s neighbour. One tick per line, every study day.

Setting up (once)

- ☐ App installed / site bookmarked, signed in with my one Google account
- ☐ One notebook per subject, named clearly
- ☐ Syllabus added as the first source in every notebook

For every new chapter

- ☐ Chapter added as a source and renamed properly
- ☐ Briefing Doc read (Studio)
- ☐ Prompt 1 — Chapter Summary run
- ☐ Study Guide generated and saved as a note
- ☐ Audio Overview generated for travel listening

Daily revision

- ☐ Prompt 4 — Rapid-Fire Test, 15 minutes
- ☐ One 10-question Quiz attempted before seeing answers
- ☐ Every wrong answer saved as a note
- ☐ At least 3 citations opened and read in the source
- ☐ Yesterday’s Audio Overview re-listened once

Weekly

- ☐ Prompt 8 — Hard Quiz on the weakest chapter
- ☐ Prompt 10 — One-Page Revision Sheet for each finished chapter
- ☐ Duplicate / wrong sources removed

That is the whole system: **your sources, your questions, verified answers, daily revision.** Start with one notebook and one chapter today — five minutes of setup, and the way you study changes for good.

— Saurabh Saha

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